

Book Review

The Present Moment in Psychotherapy and Everyday Life. Daniel M. Stern. New York: W. W. Norton and Company, 2004. 247 pages, hardbound, \$29.95.

Once again, Daniel N. Stern writes a book that is relevant and inclusive of the field of Dance/Movement Therapy. In his 1985 publication of *The Interpersonal World of the Infant: A View from Psychoanalysis and Developmental Psychology*, he addresses the phenomenon of attunement in a manner that affirms and illuminates what dance therapists know about that subject. He gives credit in a footnote to the work of Kestenberg and Sossin in the microanalysis of mother/infant interactions. In his recent publication, *The Present Moment in Psychotherapy and Everyday Life* (2004), he studies the nature, temporal architecture and organization of *nowness* using a phenomenological approach and using language that has great relevance to and overlap with the field of dance/movement therapy. He again acknowledges Judith Kestenberg, as well as Warren Lamb, Rudolf Laban and Emile Dalcroze, and their contributions to the study of movement analysis. Stern has a deep understanding of how their work helps to delineate the micro-world of the present moment as “lived experience” (p. xiii) which is the focus of his book.

Stern's book is divided into three parts. In Part One, entitled *Exploring the Present Moment*, he studies the characteristics of the present moment as a process unit that is about perceptual, subjective, psychological, and lived (as opposed to verbal) experience in the here and now. In chapter three Stern compares the duration of the present moment as it is conceived in music, movement, dance, nonverbal mother-infant interactions, and in general mental operations. He describes the temporal dynamics of moments as vitality affects that unfold as the

moment unfolds. He refers to the choreographer's attempts to get at the artistry of expression rather than just the technique, as that matches his own interest in vitality affects which have more to do with feeling than with the actual movement. Stern is talking about the "how" of movement that is thoroughly addressed both in LMA and in the Kestenberg Movement profile.

Stern wants us to think of the present moment as a short stretch of consciousness in which felt experience is expressed through vitality affects (effort/shape) and to consider such moments as offering the greatest potential for authenticity and change. He states that these moments of vitality affects are where the "magic in a therapy session or in intimate relations" (p. 67) resides. He challenges the clinical, behavioral and neurosciences to work to understand more fully phenomenal experience, i.e., the subjective experience of vitality affects.

As dance/movement therapists, we might feel some momentary frustration or excitement that Stern expresses explicitly what we know implicitly. We are very familiar with lived experience as it unfolds moment-by-moment and movement-by-movement in a Chacian group or authentic movement process. This irritation or excitement might augment as one reads further, as Stern urges the "beyond talking" (p. 142) therapies not only to stay focused on the "micro-temporal structure of the process" (p. 143), but also to pay more attention "to its detailed description and conceptualization." (p. 143)

In Part II, *Contextualizing the Present Moment*, Stern further explores the present moment through the lens of intersubjectivity and asks how the present moment is experienced by dyads and groups when it is co-created and shared in a moment of intersubjective contact. He is most interested in, and wants the reader to be interested in, the feeling/experiencing realm.

Stern outlines the neuroscientific evidence of "mirror neurons" (p. 78) and the neurobiological mechanisms, which allow one to read, empathize and resonate with another person's state of mind, intentions, experience, or movement. He raises the question of how a present moment that is implicitly grasped becomes conscious. He contrasts the introspective, or reflective, consciousness that takes place verbally in most therapies with the phenomenal consciousness "usually synonymous with enactments" (p. 125) stressed in movement, drama and other "existentially oriented therapies." He suggests a new form of consciousness, which he calls intersubjective consciousness, in which the phenomenal consciousness of one overlaps with that of another, out of which an intersubjective experience, or a "shared feeling voyage" (p. 173) is co-created. The participants have a social experience of sharing similar landscapes of feeling (p. 246) that feels mutually validating. Reflective consciousness, states Stern, happens when one experiences the other's experience of one's experience.

From the perspective of a dance/movement therapist, reading this section of the book might cause a sense of “of course.” Marion Chace developed a whole method of therapy and change based on the ability to connect through kinesthetic empathy and attunement to the vitality affects and felt experience of others. Some of what Stern talks about we take for granted; nevertheless, there can also be an exhilarating sense of validation that the neurosciences are catching up to us and that our field can now come into its own.

In Part Three, *Views from a Clinical Perspective*, Stern urges clinicians to put the present moment on “center stage” in the clinical setting, so as to see the richness of intimate human relations and psychotherapy at the micro level of moments that occupy a subjective *now*. Stern cites the work of the expressive therapies for their focus on what is unfolding at the present centered interaction as the context of the emerging material. He makes a criticism that often we then proceed to do what most verbal therapies do; i.e., move into the content or the explicit and therefore lose much of the “wholeness, felt truth, richness, and honesty” of the lived moment. Stern becomes quite impassioned here as he answers his self-imposed question of whether he is giving action and/or joint action precedence over thought and language. He reminds himself and us that such a question is irrelevant when we understand the cognitive sciences’ proposal that the mind is not an independent disembodied entity. “Rather, thinking itself requires and depends upon feelings emanating from the body.” (p. 145) Change, he says, can come not only through interpretation (psychoanalytic) in the explicit domain, but also through shifts in implicit knowing. As implicit knowing is given more importance, so also more importance is given to action and non-verbal present moments in which intersubjective contact takes place through mutual gaze, postural shifts, gestures, facial expressions, respiratory changes or changes in vocal tone or strength.

The final chapters document therapy as a co-created journey in which it is understood that the client brings a desire to be known and a desire for intersubjective contact that both drives the psychotherapeutic process forward and also regulates it. Stern reveals his keen interest in dance and movement process as he couches and speaks of the therapeutic process in choreographic language and uses such phrases as “the moving along process, relational moves, process flow, missteps in the dance, presentness fills the time and space, choreography of intention movements.” The dance that Stern describes is one in which the implicit is at the forefront and which culminates in a peak experience that he calls a “moment of meeting.” (p. 151) These moments take place in *kairos*, a Greek term for time in which there is an emergent sense of something coming into being. This something is experienced affectively through the

expression of vitality affects and intersubjectively as “doing something together” (p. 176), whether it is mental, affective or physical.

Stern uses the wonderful phrase, “interweaving the implicit and explicit” (p. 187), to describe a client expressing herself, and the therapist listening and participating in the experience, as it gets relived explicitly through words, but also through the implicit expression of “ease, difficulty, groping, hesitating, blocking, frustration, effort, changes in flow, speed, volume and force...” (p. 193). Stern aptly names this as a performance that evokes in both the listener and the teller a stream of implicit experiencing.

This section of the book lays to rest the many discussions I have been privy to among dance/movement therapists regarding whether words are necessary to process the experience. Our job, according to Stern, is to pay attention and respond to the implicit experience, to the felt experience, to the vitality affects or effort/shape expression, whether in the form of language or movement. It is the *now moments* followed by a *moment of meeting*, in which the participants are focused on the presentness of the current lived moment, that change happens in relationships.

Reading Stern offers the dance/movement therapist an opportunity for an experience of parallel process, or perhaps more accurately, a kind of virtual *moment of meeting* in the intersubjective matrix. His understanding of dance and movement process serves as metaphor for his new views on what is essential and meaningful in human interaction and in the change process of psychotherapy. His writing mirrors what the field of dance/therapy knows implicitly and struggles to express in explicit forms. Stern lets us know that we are at the cutting edge of the neuroscience of interpersonal relating. We need to take our rightful place and to enter into an intersubjective dialogue in which we share our knowledge and respond/contribute to this exciting new “moment of meeting.”

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